What the Room Called Waste

One-page preaching outline — Mary of Bethany

Primary text: John 12:1–8 **Also read:** Mark 14:3–9 · Matthew 26:6–13 · Luke 10:38–42 · John 11:1–44 **Big idea:** Love that has understood the cross stops calculating what devotion is worth. **Time:** 55–60 minutes, including a 3–5 minute response (6,653 words at about 125 wpm). **Aim:** Move the room from auditing Mary's devotion to naming its own sealed jar and seeing the cross as love without calculation.

MOVEMENT MAP

MIN	SECTION	BEATS AND TRANSITION
5	**Introduction: The smell in the room**	The fragrance fills the house before anyone explains it. Six days before Passover, a wanted man sits at Simon the leper's table; Lazarus is alive, Martha serves, Mary stands with the jar. → *"Before we watch what she does, I want you to look around the room."*
6	**The room full of evidence**	Simon, Lazarus, Martha, Jesus. The room has seen resurrection and still can do the math. Evidence is not faith. → *"The room was full of evidence. And the room was about to call love a waste."*
7	**The woman who had been listening**	Three scenes at Jesus' feet: sitting (Luke 10), weeping (John 11), anointing (John 12). She heard him speak of death. The room awaited a crown; Mary prepared a burial. → *"She had been listening. That is the first thing the room had stopped doing."*
8	**The jar that could not be saved**	Three hundred denarii; imported nard; the flask is broken, not portioned; her hair is the towel; worship fills the room. Not "sell everything" but "stop calculating what devotion is worth." → *"Mary broke hers. And the room has never forgotten the smell."*
8	**The objection that sounds spiritual**	"And someone objected." "Why this waste?" Deuteronomy 15:11 commands generosity, not neglect. Judas is a thief; 300 denarii against 30 pieces of silver. Jesus defends her; we are defended by him. → *"The question is not whether you have asked, 'Why this waste?' The question is whether you will let him answer it."*
8	**The burial she understood**	"She has anointed my body beforehand for burial." The Passover Lamb is examined by priests and governor, condemned by the crowd, killed outside the gate. The cross is love without calculation; the tomb is empty; her story goes wherever the gospel goes. → *"The question is whether we will join her."*
7	**Application: What do you do with the jar?**	Name the jar. Do one uncalculated act. Stop auditing someone else's devotion. Make room for grief. → *"You cannot manufacture this kind of love."*
3	**The invitation**	Not "try harder" but "come closer." The one who defended Mary went to the cross for the people who called it waste. → *"You can come back. You can open your hands. You can let him answer for you. You can stay."*
5	**Response and closing**	Silence. Name the jar. Ask, "What would it look like to love you without calculating?" Commit to one act. Pray. → *"She broke the jar. He emptied the tomb. And he made sure she would never be forgotten."*

Total: 57 minutes with a full response; 55–60 with normal variation.

LINES TO LAND

- **The witness:** "The room could not ignore what had happened. The room could not pretend it had not seen. The smell was the witness."
- **The cost:** "And she is not giving him a portion. She is giving him the container."
- **The verdict:** "The room called it waste. Jesus called it beautiful."
- **The gospel:** "He did not come for the people who got it right. He came for the room that got it wrong."

GUARDRAILS

- This is not a stewardship lecture. Keep the focus on devotion, not other people's money.
- Hold both halves of Deuteronomy 15:11: care for the poor and costly worship. Do not let the room choose.
- Do not cartoon Judas. His question is real; John names the motive.
- Keep Mary of Bethany distinct from Mary Magdalene and Luke 7's woman; do not claim more than the text says about how much she understood.
- Protect Movements 2, 3, and 5, the invitation, and the response.

IF YOU MUST CUT

- **To 50 minutes:** Introduction to 4, Movement 1 to 4, Movement 4 to 6, Application to 5. Keep the 300-vs-30 contrast and all four applications, tightened.
- **Never cut:** the three scenes at Jesus' feet, the jar broken, the burial interpretation, the invitation, and the silence.